

The Saigon Circle

In January 1968, the high command in Hanoi was ready to launch the Tet Offensive, simultaneous attacks on South Vietnam's cities. Their prime target was the "Saigon Circle," which included the US Embassy and the ARVN headquarters at nearby Bien Hoa.

◀◀ BEFORE

Before the Tet Offensive, Saigon and its surroundings had been relatively tranquil.

PARIS OF THE ORIENT

Before the war, South Vietnam's capital felt like a largely **French city**, with its tree-lined avenues, colonial villas, and Catholic churches. French and Vietnamese were the main languages. Until 1968, the South Vietnamese capital had been **comparatively free of violence**.

PRELIMINARY ATTACKS

Isolated **US Combat bases along the DMZ** had experienced bouts of fierce fighting through the summer and fall of 1967.

By January 1968, some 84,000 NVA and Viet Cong troops had taken up attack positions between the Mekong Delta and the DMZ. Ordered out of their jungle bases by the communist leadership in Hanoi, the Viet Cong secretly entered cities and towns across South Vietnam in readiness for a major offensive scheduled for Tet, the Vietnamese New Year, on January 31.

It was anticipated that many ARVN soldiers would be on leave over the holiday and urban areas filled with out-of-town visitors, providing a perfect cover for the civilian-clad Viet Cong to blend in with the general population. Meanwhile, NVA troops, who had been infiltrating South Vietnam since the previous summer, were set to take part in coordinated attacks on combat bases along the DMZ.

The infiltration coincided with the announcement of a ceasefire over the Tet holiday by both the Saigon government and the National Liberation Front (NLF), the political wing of the communists in the South. With South Vietnam lulled into a false sense of security, the stage was set for the massive and unprecedented assault.

35 The number of communist battalions, totaling 35,000 men, in the Saigon Circle at Tet.

27 The number of US and ARVN battalions around Saigon, boosted from the initial 14 after the intervention of US General Weyand.